AI EXPLAINED SIMPLY

Cheat sheet: 3 free AI tools to study smarter

Notes in, practice exam out. Here is what each tool does, how to start in two minutes, and what to watch for.

1. NotebookLM (Google)

- **What it does:** you add your own sources (notes, PDFs) and it generates flashcards and quizzes grounded in that material.
- **Added:** September 2025. Available on the free plan (free-plan daily limits may apply).
- **Start:** open NotebookLM, create a notebook, upload your PDF or notes, then open the Flashcards and Quiz tools.
- **Tip:** use the explain button on a wrong answer to see why it was wrong.

2. Anki

- **What it does:** flashcard app that schedules each card using spaced repetition.
- **Cost:** the desktop app is free and open source. Syncing through AnkiWeb is free. The official iOS app is a paid one-time purchase.
- **FSRS:** since Anki 23.10 you can switch the scheduler to FSRS (Settings > Scheduling > Enable FSRS). Anki's FAQ says it needs fewer reviews than the default algorithm for the same retention.
- **Start:** install Anki on desktop, make a deck from your NotebookLM flashcards, enable FSRS, review a few minutes a day.

3. Gemini Guided Learning

- **What it does:** a Gemini mode that acts as a tutor. It breaks problems into steps and explains the reasoning instead of just giving the answer.
- **Start:** in the Gemini app, pick Guided Learning next to the prompt box, then paste the topic or problem you are stuck on.

A simple evening routine

1. Upload your notes to NotebookLM and generate a quiz.
2. Move the cards you miss into Anki.
3. Ask Gemini Guided Learning to walk you through the topics you keep missing.

Sources

- Google Workspace Updates / 9to5Google, Sept 2025 (NotebookLM flashcards and quizzes)
- Anki FAQ: What spaced repetition algorithm does Anki use? (docs.ankiweb.net)
- Google blog, Aug 2025: new Gemini tools for students (Guided Learning)

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